1

The sled, nearly overburdened with crates, slammed the floor and sent jarring vibrations up his legs. The resulting *clang* hurt the ears, but there was satisfaction in that sound. That sound meant the job was near finished. The goods delivered, he could collect the payment, then be on his merry way. He'd fly back, get his cut, then wait for another job. The repetition would be mind-numbingly boring if something *interesting* didn't happen as often as it did, but if he made it far enough to hear that clang of the crates without any hiccups, that usually meant he was in the clear.

The recipients sauntered up to the crates to finish inspecting their wares. Skepticism marked their mien, or at least, he *thought* he noticed skepticism; Rodians had a few different facial expressions that he wasn't so great at always distinguishing. Maybe they were doubting…maybe they were intrigued. Regardless, he tossed a glance beside him at the towering figure on his right, then eyed his associate's bowcaster. Receptively, the shaggy giant tightened his grip on the weapon, and he hovered his hand at his thigh. A strongbox–the payment, out of which would come his cut–dangled in the grip of a none-too-bright Rodian towards the back of the party. If they had to fight to get what was theirs, so be it: he was not leaving here empty-handed.

The lid to the crate hissed all the way open and the large dark eyes of the lead Rodian traced the interior. A single suckered-ended digit reached in and plucked out a vial. Inside the transparent tube, small cubes of white tumbled as the Rodian lifted it to be examined under the magnifier of his head gear. Delicately, he turned the vial in the light as he scrutinized. A few seconds of tense silence went by before he threw his arm down violently.

"This is not the same quality as you demonstrated to us!" the Rodian asserted in his native tongue, his proboscis bobbing up and

down as he yelled. "We will not be accepting this shipment."

"What are you talkin' about?" the man countered, taking a step forward. "That's the same as what I showed you. Took the vial right out of the case–you saw." He shrugged, trying to play innocent. "Maybe there's some quality control issues back on S-Two. Check another one." And with that, he glanced down at the crate, outwardly appearing cool despite a racing heart: what happened next wholly depended on the contents of the vial chosen.

The Rodian stood still for a moment, clearly conflicted, but gave in to the suggestion with an irritated snort. Turning his attention back to the crate, he scoped the insides and selected a second vial. Again, he raised it up for inspection.

"Difficult to get a hold of highly refined andris these days," the man intoned, turning his chin as though to scan over the group but keeping the leader in his peripheral vision. "Empire seems interested in keeping the good stuff out of everyone's hands 'cept their soldiers. Leaves the rest of us scamper about for the low grade dregs."

"Shut up," one of the other Rodians barked back.

The man held his hands up. "Hey, just tryin' to make conversation."

"Your Basic human drolling is unnecessary," the leader interjected. "We're all aware of the supply issues of andris." He chucked the vial at the man. "Look at this yourself–it's dingy."

As instructed, the man turned the vial up to the harsh lights of the docking bay. The white crystals, if they really were high grade refined andris, should have been perfect, snow white cubes. What he was staring at, however, retained some of the tan color of the lesser andris and crumbled a bit too easily. The purity of the drug would control just how much it could heighten the senses. Regular andris was allegedly pleasant, but the refined andris could apparently make a simple, half-assed cooked tralandon steak taste like the single best thing you'd ever eaten. Not that he knew firsthand–he'd not *been* a smuggler for long, but he'd *known* smugglers for a while, damn near his whole life. They had cardinal rules that the longest lived ones

swore by, and the top one was to not get messed up in the goods.

"I dunno, this looks the same to me," he lied, then chucked the vial back. He pointed up at the ceiling. "Maybe these lights are screwing with you."

"The only thing screwing with us is you, Captain…Captain…" The Rodian leader paused. "What did you say your name was?"

The prospect of lying shot to the forefront of his mind, and he quickly weighed his options. This wasn't guaranteed to go sour yet. That they were still talking was a good sign. If he could walk out of here with everybody decently happy and intact, it'd be good for them to know who he was. A name–a reputation–was everything. "Solo," he finally answered. "Captain Solo."

"Captain Solo, this is not the same quality andris as you displayed. Neither vial has proven this stock to be worth the price." With that, the Rodian returned the vial to the crate, then turned to leave.

"So change the price," Solo countered. The Rodian halted, midstep…listening. "Listen, what I was told to pick up for you was highly refined andris. That's what I did, that's what I brought here. I get it if you're not so happy with the quality–I guess those refineries in Sevarcos II are slipping, and I'll bring it up with my bosses when I return. But this," he gestured at the crate, "is still well refined andris, it's still worth a hard coin, and buyers are rarely sharp enough to catch any difference in quality." He threw his hands on his hips. "Hell, I'll take less for it, and you can still tell your buyers it's top tier."

The Rodian considered him for a moment. "What will the Hutts say if you show up with less than the agreed upon amount? We want no quarrels with them."

He grinned, a half-smirk that he knew looked good on him, maybe even to a Rodian. "I'm tight with 'em. If I explain, they'll understand."

The group turned to each other and discussed, their intelligibility decreased as the group squawked and screeched. Solo's eyes darted from figure to figure, trying to ascertain from body

language then whether the tide was turning his way or it was time to pull his blaster. For as animated as they were, they didn't *seem* especially agitated; rather, from what little he could gather in the cacophony, he thought he heard enthusiasm. He grinned internally. *Money tends to do that to people.*

"Okay, Captain Solo, agreed," the leader finally said. "We'll cut off a thousand from the top."

He quickly did the math in his head of what that would mean for him–it was obviously less than he'd been hoping for, but still a win. "Sounds fair to me," he answered with a forced smile, then stifled any evidence of his disappointment as the strongbox was opened and the agreed-upon stack of credits removed. His cut of ten percent would mean he just lost out on an extra hundred credits, which wasn't life changing, but those little wins added up.

"Pleasure doing business with you," the leader affirmed as he offered up a hand. Solo took it and shook, ignoring the off-putting suckle of the Rodian's fingertips on his wrist.

"Can't wait to come back," he fibbed through clenched teeth. He accepted the strongbox from one of the peons and then forced himself to walk slowly and confidently back up the gangplank of his ship, a *Starmite* class vessel with a dull red hull that had seen better days. Behind him came the tall, furry consociate, and when they were both secured inside, his fist hit the controls for the plank. It whirled and groaned and let go of a torrent of compressed air, and with it, Solo let out a long sigh. His hand went to his breastbone–had his chest been tight this whole time?

[*Why do I have the feeling you did something you didn't tell me about*?] the Wookiee growled, his deep-set blue eyes staring down at Solo with a tired displeasure.

He straightened and smiled confidently; sometimes it was a good thing that Chewie only spoke Shyriiwook and Basic. "Nothing I'm not a trained hand at."

[*You need to tell me this kind of thing. If I had known–*]

"If you'd known, you woulda ruined it," Solo contradicted. "I

have to watch what I tell you, or you let your conscience get in the way of everything." He lifted up the strongbox, handing it off. "Put this somewhere." At that, Solo pushed past the Wookiee, heading further into the ship.

The cockpit resided only a few more strides down the corridor. The interior glowed in the blinking orange and green lights of an already warmed engine–he learned long ago to always keep her at the ready, just in case. His captain's chair creaked as he swiveled it to receive him and hands went to the radio to call the local tower for ground clearance.

As he waited for a response, his hands went into the inside pocket of his vest and pulled out a vial. Smirking, he turned it up to the lights outside his view window. Inside, bright white cubes nearly sparkled in the light as he twisted the container in his fingertips. They didn't normally come to Rodia, and they didn't normally smuggle andris. Convenient, then, that he'd happened to overhear at a bar that someone out this way sought to trade some disappointing stock for something of a higher caliber, and was willing to pay a handsome sum in order to get the good stuff quick. He'd taken the buyer–a Devaronian female–up on the offer, and Chewie, his copilot, hadn't questioned too closely when he insisted they needed to make a quick stopover on Piroket for a rare part for the ship. The trade had been simple, and the Rodians who received the lower grade crates…that had been close, but he'd squeaked through. That was all he needed sometimes.

[*So there was no pickup of a valve for the coaxium regulator*.] Chewie's tone was flat as he entered, and he squeezed himself into the just-too-small seat for the copilot. [*Han, you cannot keep putting that off. That regulator blows and*–]

"I know," Han snapped, discreetly tucking the vial back into his jacket. "Soon as we get back, I'll ask Shug about it." His shoulders fell. "I mean, I already asked him about it a while ago, but I didn't have the money on me for the parts he drummed up. Maybe he'll be able to dig up another set."

The radio continued to beep as his call awaited a response. The tickle of impatience started in his hands, and he flexed his fingers, trying to divert his attention elsewhere.

[*I'm hungry*] the Wookiee grumbled low in the punctuated silence.

"You're always hungry," Han rebuked, though now that the Wook mentioned it, his insides too were twisting in protest. His appetite always shrank before a stint then came back with a vengeance.

He jerked a thumb behind him. "Those crates secured back there? I ain't interested in spilling Rodian hemolymph all over the cargo bay."

[*That was one time*] Chewie retorted [*and **you** were the one who missed that buckle, not me.*]

"Can't believe I'm even carting that shit around," Han griped, ignoring the rebuttal. "Bunch of bug goop."

[*It'd be a waste if we deadheaded.*]

Han's shoulders slumped: that was true. It would be a waste– of fuel, time, money–to come back from all this way with nothing in the cargo bay. Still.

The radio finally beeped and whirled: an astromech droid from ATC identified the ship with its string of letters and numbers that stood in for a name on the transponder code. Both Han and Chewie's screen lit up with reception of the request to take off.

[*Wonder how long we'll wait for clearance.*] Chewie's question was offhanded, a musing.

Han bristled again. "Better not be long. I don't know who those Rodians are workin' with in customs. I want out of here before anybody sniffs anything funny…or sells anybody out." He stretched his neck to gawk at his copilot. "The two of us ain't exactly standard fare here. 'Specially you. Hard to riff an alibi."

Chewie miffed. [*Harder still with that vial in your pocket.*]

Han snorted a laugh. "Eh, I'd chuck it. Nobody would notice."

With another whirl of beeps and whistles, the ATC droid announced their approval for departure. Both pilot and copilot resumed their duties, one monitoring screens and systems and comms while the other busied himself with the controls of the ship and their route in the sky. Once they cleared atmo, Chewie's responsibility also became talking to the ship's navicomputer, putting in their desired coordinates and waiting for the giant thinking machine to run the logistics. It needed to process positions, speeds, competing gravity wells, and nearby vessels to mark the trajectory–sometimes a sliver of space, all things considered–that would keep them out of harm's way.

Meanwhile, Han piloted, cautious to maintain safe distance from the multitude of other ships coming and going from Rodia. This busyness…he preferred it, in a way. There was an aspect of smuggling that relied on middle-of-nowhere locations: pitstops and depots and abandoned asteroid fields and even, he recalled, the dead of space. But getting caught there meant having few believable cover stories. Here, in the churn of a hectic place…yeah, there were more eyes watching, but they were just another ship.

Still, Han surveyed, and in doing so, caught the slow float of a patrol. Local, he surmised, judging by the build and age of the vessel. They appeared not particularly interested in them, but that could change fast.

"You gotta timer on that thing?" Han questioned, a touch of strain to his voice.

[*It keeps resetting*] Chewie grumbled. [*Class Five dross*.]

"Is it the hyperdrive, the motivator, or the nav?" Han questioned.

Chewie rumbled in wry disappointment. [*The rate things have been, probably all–*]

"No, don't jinx it," Han snapped. "You'll speak it into existence, and then we'll be fucked." He really wasn't superstitious, not like how the rest of them were. Definitely not like the Nar Shaddese. But for something that big, he wasn't chancing it. "It just…it just needs a little time." And as he said it, he checked the

patrol again. Clear so far.

[*Okay. Thirty seconds*.]

Maximum of thirty seconds to approach the entrance to the hyperspace lane and engage the hyperdrive. Not a lot of time in concept, but an eon if they needed to move. That patrol didn't look big enough to have its own tractor beam, but his eyes scanned the radar, checking out one of the libration points, and he could see the familiar cone of a stationary tower. At a word, that thing could reach out and snatch them, hold them in place even if he upped his sublight engines to full throttle. That would mean boarding, scrutiny of his manifest, his ship getting turned over…and that was if things went well.

[*That patrol*] Chewie started with a nervous edge. [*It's pivoting*.]

Han's attention snapped back to his own screen, then squinted out the view window. Indeed, the ship was yawing more into their direction, matching the movement of his Sorosuub. Tense, he waited for sensors to pick up any readings, then scowled at the alert of a scan.

"We'll beat 'em to the hyperspace entrance," he announced, more thinking aloud than stated fact, then hurriedly checked their speed. At the rate they were going, it left a lot of time. He couldn't boost anything now, not under scrutiny. What a tell. And still twenty seconds left on the nav…

He scanned the field, running through options, then saw his opening: a giant cruiser, a passenger ship, was intersecting his heading. He as the smaller vessel had the responsibility to course correct. He could simply speed up, but doing so would bring him closer to the patrol. Instead, he cut back the engines, let the ship float for a bit, a convenient delay, then moved her around to the other side of the cruiser. The scan alert dropped, and triple checking his heading, he sped them back up, surpassing his previous cruising speed.

[*Five*] Chewie announced.

Han's hand reached out, pinching the lever to engage the

hyperdrive in readiness. They'd hit the entrance to the lane just as the timer dropped. They only needed a few more seconds.

[*Another scan*] Chewie announced as their screen lit up with the alert.

"Kiss my ass," Han muttered under his breath, a wry grin tugging at his lips as he dropped the lever and watched space bend and twist before them.

* * *

58…59, he finished counting, then repeated the total back to himself: 2,459.

His brow furrowed. *The hell*, he scowled, twisting to grope the inside of the chest tucked at his bunkside. His fingers clanked around, smacking sidewalls, sure at each movement that he'd hit another stack of coin. Yet a few rounds of searching and…nothing.

He sat up with a knit brow. There was no way that was it–he should have at least 3,500 total. He scrutinized the pile in front of him again, piecing through the stacks, double checking that none had accidentally been misassigned a denomination. After that, he pulled open the top drawer of his side table, hoping to hear the metallic slosh of credits that maybe he'd dropped in a distracted or mildly drunken cloud. He heard metal, causing an anticipatory flutter of relief, but grunted it away as he pushed around a pile of IDs, all of them coded with his face but bearing some other name. No money. He hovered for a breath, staring at the drawer, pondering if perhaps he had left some money back at the apartment. He winced at the false hope: no, he had his habits, long engrained, and he wouldn't drop money anywhere but in an account or in the safe.

He sat back, looking long at the money now sprawled across his lap, frowning hard. This was it–twenty-five hundred credits was all he had to show for the time and the sweat. The risk. That kind of money could disappear tomorrow–a short circuit on damn near

anything in his engine room, and this money would not only be gone, but he'd be short. Stranded. *Again*.

He ran a hand over his face. He hadn't imagined it was going to be like this. The life of a smuggler, that was supposed to be *easy*. Carefree. Hell, at least lucrative. It hadn't been his first choice, but his first choice–his jaw clenched to remember–hadn't panned out. Smuggling was something he figured he could do, and do well, something that would put his piloting and his problem-solving and his people-watching to work. He figured those skills might catapult him to the top. He hadn't calculated that he was just one of many who could fly and didn't mind–or maybe enjoyed–the recklessness of doing business with the Hutts. The unstructuredness, sometimes lawlessness, of the Mid and Outer Rim. That owning a ship meant responsibility a lot more than it meant freedom.

There *was* freedom, he had to give the job that. He didn't really have to answer to anybody; the Hutts were bosses, yeah, but not in that way. Ultimately, he was an independent contractor, gambling with his own ship and, he knew, his life in exchange for the ability to not take a job. To pick up and go somewhere else, if it pleased him. If he needed to. Captain of his own ship, he was his own man, making his own decisions, living by his own rules…and victim to his own shortcomings.

He grumbled as he started to cup the stacks into his palm to put back. Surely, it all would pay off soon. Surely, at some point, this damn ship would finally stop bleeding him dry. Surely, he'd get her stable enough to take some of the riskier jobs, the ones that paid more. It had only been a year, he reminded himself, and only six months in this little 'Suub. He'd get there, he told himself, though he heard how weak it sounded, then tried again. He'd squeak by, if he had to. Or maybe, as he'd just pulled off on Rodia, run some more side cons for a little extra coin. Whatever it took, he'd do it. He'd have to–there wasn't any going back. His brow tensed at the fuller truth: there wasn't anywhere to go back *to*.

The *Starmite* was a small vessel, really only fit to handle a

max of three passengers, so the sudden alternating chime from the navicomputer that they were nearing their destination filled his little bunkroom. He tiredly dragged his hand down his face again and reset his expression, then gathered himself and headed into the cockpit. Chewie was already there, preparing to monitor the ship's systems and the local vector when they came out of hyperspace. Out the view window, a vortex of blue and white spun before them, an alternate to real time and space twisting in accommodation to the ship's hyperdrive.

Han found his seat and mumbled a few instructions off to his copilot, to which the Wookiee trilled a response. They'd already done this three times this trip, as the return from Rodia required entering and exiting multiple different hyperspace lanes. This current exit, though, would be the last for this trip, and finally: the ship, with her subpar hyperdrive, took longer than he was used to. Sitting in this cramped space for eight, nine straight hours was enough to make anyone go stir-crazy.

"Exiting hyperspace…now," Han announced, his hand reaching out to the throttle and pinching it between his extended thumb and pinky.

The vortex fell back. Everything before them was still. Silent. Now out his view window was a familiar sight: the giant blue ball and the mottled brown disk behind it.

He tensely turned to Chewie, eyeing the screens before him. "Anyone else out here?"

[*Not picking up anything on the sensors. It's quiet today.*]

It's never quiet, Han mused to himself, w*e just rarely come this way*. Though his copilot had given him the all-clear, he scoped the vicinity. Pirates liked to sit out here, just outside hyperspace terminals. They'd crouch and wait for their quarry to come into realspace, tired from a long journey and anxious to touch solid ground. When the coast looked clear and you got comfortable, that's when the pirates would strike. They'd wreck your ship enough to board you, then take everything they could. Afterwards, maybe they

killed you. Maybe they took you hostage for ransom. And there was always, of course, the option of selling you into slavery.

Coming out of hyperspace this close to the gravity well of such a large planet meant he could let the ship coast her way towards their terminal. Only with a few spurts of the sublight engines did they escape the pull of the larger planet and head on their way to that brown moon behind the waterworld. The closer they came, the more the details of the satellite came into view, though there wasn't much to take in. The place had no resources, no significant industries, nothing of inherent value for itself or the larger segment of space. It was wholly undesirable on its own merits, sitting in the rocky wing of the galaxy with no shortage of much more habitable worlds. The moon's only redeeming quality was its proximity to the larger entities of the galaxy. Numerous political organizations existed just beyond the reach of this space, and the proximate area around it was a criss-cross of hyperspace lanes. That meant it had access while also being just far enough away that it could escape domination from any one other locale or power. And thus, Nar Shaddaa was perfectly suited to be the headquarters of the Hutts.

Of course, the Hutts were not native to this place–they came from Nal Hutta, the beautiful blue marble around which Nar Shaddaa orbited. But far be it for the Hutts to be content with what they were given, or to be able to share it peacefully amongst themselves. The Hutts had split long ago into a handful of competing *kajidic* or clans, and one *kajidic*, the Desilijic, had come to the ecumenopolis of Nar Shaddaa and pushed out the locals to claim a sizable section of the moon as theirs. They were generalists of a sort, organizing illegal trade in all kinds of goods from the mundane to the illicit to the rare. The Desilijic ran the region known as Kha'art Hadash and its myriad sectors, calling the ancient palace in the center home. Overall, the area was a swamp wrapped in crumbling infrastructure and shoddily completed development with too many people and too much garbage and too little administration. But even a rancor will defend a worthless scrap of meat if she can call it *hers*, and thus the Desilijic

were unceasing in their attempts to protect their domain and use it to undermine their multitude of cousins and competing clans. Of utmost exigency was the constant clash with the Besadii *kajidic*, who as of now held the upper hand. Han had actually worked for them as a pilot years ago, though he was averse to freely admitting it to the Desilijic–Hutts were nothing if not temperamental, and the threat to the status of his current employment was the least of his concerns if he dredged up any reason to be accused of subversion.

The 'Suub crossed the barrier that divided the exosphere from the rest of space. Han radioed into the Spacebarn, still trying to monitor systems as he did so.

"Solo, that you in that beat up ship?" a voice answered on the radio. "She actually made it back?"

Han smirked, ignoring the dig. "Shug! What are you doin' workin' the radio?"

"Somebody's gotta keep this place in check," the mechanic answered back, followed by a chuckle. "Actually, just happened to be in the office."

"How's she been while we were gone?"

"Ah, skies are busy as always."

"Anybody interesting?"

Shug seemed to understand what Han was asking. "Nobody who has your number, I don't think."

Though pleased to not have garnered any unwelcome interest, Han grimaced. Keeping tabs on any big names–bounty hunters, in particular–was simply good insurance. He'd had a few on his heels years ago, courtesy of his dramatic exit from the Besadii's service. He'd disposed of one of them and then the rest had dropped off. Whether he'd made his point or the Besadii simply let it go, he wasn't sure. As for Shrike…well, it was anyone's guess what the drunk fuck was up to. In a just world, he'd be dead, and hopefully, it had been drawn out and painful. But he, too, had been pretty sour when Han had left, and Shrike had always been bad about hanging onto grudges.

So far, Han had evaded any notice since arriving on the Smuggler's Moon; he'd like to keep it that way.

He fiddled with some of the controls to prep them for descent. "Alrighty, I'm headed down. Bay seven?" he asked, then gestured over to Chewie to plug in the request to the Nar Shaddese ATC.

There was a pause, then an audible huff, even over the crackle of the radio. "Sorry, Han," Shug eventually answered. "I ain't got room in here."

Han gaped at the radio. "You gave up my spot?!"

"You didn't pay to keep it," the mechanic answered smoothly.

"I was paid up for a month!"

Another pause, then, "You were paid up for a month *over* a month ago."

At that, Han froze, trying to make sense of the timeline. Truthfully, he couldn't even put together how much time had passed since they'd left Nar Shaddaa. Not really. Sure, it had only seemed like a handful of days to them, but…

"How long we been gone?" Han queried quietly to his copilot.

The Wookiee was quick to check. [*About three weeks*] he answered.

Han's brow raised in surprise–that was much longer than he would have surmised. Time swirled and disappeared, it seemed, in this life.

"That time dilation's a bitch," Shug interjected. "Not a bad idea for you to put feet on the ground for a while. Take some time."

Han winced at the suggestion, then brushed it aside. "You don't have *any* empties?" he continued. "Something I can just drop in for a stretch, until something official opens up?"

"Sorry, Solo. I'm all full down here."

"Alright," Han sighed. "Listen, I'll dock at the Hutt Palace. I'll get square with them then head over to yours."

"Works for me," the mechanic said, and without further niceties, the line clicked dead.

Their descent onto the moon went smoothly enough. They

broke atmosphere then swooped down into a long, mostly graceful curve. Though his instruments could have blindly led him to his destination, Han still peered out the view window, taking in the mottled mix of gray and brown of Kha'art Hadash. Their route took them over the exhaust-laden Industrial Sector, home to what little manufacturing and recycling industries existed, as well as a sizable waste management facility and grounds. The port sat nearby, the area above it buzzing with a slew of short and long range vehicles, with the major shipping docks abutting the warehouse and sales sector. To the north he could spot the entertainment district, which offered little besides a beating from some unforgiving bookies and watered down liquor with a side of venereal disease. The Corellian Sector, where he put down his head when planetside, lay just east, and at the center of these districts sat the Hutt Palace. The sprawling complex was surrounded by a huge square, offering seclusion from the other wretched sectors.

Han spotted the entrance to the Palace hangar and brought them in low, masterfully grazing the craft just above the ground as they floated into the building. He picked out a spot to land just near the entrance. His hands moved across the controls in the sequence drilled into him years ago—throttle, repulsors, attitude adjust, gear down—each input precisely timed, no motion wasted. He eased them down, felt the landing gear kiss permacrete. The ship would take it the rest of the way, and he let her go. The hydraulics slowly lowered them. Steam billowed out from the gears into his view window. Then they abruptly gave with a lurch and a crunch of metal. Han sat back in his seat and groaned. He'd forgotten: the landing gear was also on his list.

They were up and out of the cockpit quick, Han heading straight to the storage room to fetch the strongbox. He stopped at the doorway, having forgotten that he had the crates of hemolymph tucked in tight, then frowned as he reached up and over them to grab the handle of the bulky metal box. He tugged it closer to him, then paused a moment, reflecting on his next move one last time. He'd spent a fair portion of the trip back debating what exactly to do about

his strongbox showing up a little *lighter* than the Hutts would expect. What seemed smartest at first was to make someone else take the fall, to insist that it was someone else who'd fucked up. The supplier on Sevarcos II being a smidge too sloppy or the middleman on Socorro skimming some off the top or the Rodians being too stingy wouldn't be hard stories to sell. And yet, he wondered…he'd never shortchanged the Hutts before. He hadn't heard of anyone who had. Cheekily, he'd finally decided it might be worth it just let it play out. If they snagged him, he always had an excuse in his back pocket. If not, well then, another deal finely executed.

Chewie stood near the top of the gangplank as Han came around the corner. The apprehension on the Wookiee's face, even in the dim yellow of their landing lighting, was unmistakable.

"Yeah," Han grumbled, disappointed himself. "Let's just get it over with."

At that, Han sucked in a breath, like the kind of big inhale before going under water, and hit the release for the gangplank. He waited, wondering for a split second as nothing seemed to happen if it wasn't as bad this time, if maybe he'd finally gotten used to it, but then–as always–an oppressive heat hit him, and he regrettably let go of that held breath, then braced against the inevitable.

For all the time he'd been here, he still had not yet gone noseblind to the fetid stink of this place that perpetually hung in the air. His stomach turned at the smell of whatever rotting garbage or pollution or mephitis caused the almost tangibly thick odor. And to add insult to injury, the stench reliably hung alongside a pervasive, heavy humidity. He pinched his shirt off him and shrugged his shoulders in a vain attempt to escape the suffocating dampness of the midday moon. As always, he loathed this initial moment of adjustment–the concentrated moisture forced him to take in a deep inhale in order to pull enough air, and then he'd get stuck inhaling clouds of miasma. And rather than the Hutt Palace being one of the few places of refuge from the experience, considering the wealth and resources of the place, being anywhere around the grounds only added

the additional effluvium of the Hutts.

They crossed through the hangar with ease, their gaze locked on the doorway at the back that would lead to the accounting manager. They passed ship after ship, some of them unrecognizable, but a few of them all-too familiar: when Han and Chewie had started flying for the Hutts, they had begun by flying from this fleet, a collection of renter ships that made his 'Suub steady in comparison. After some frustrating trial and error, Han had found at least one he tried to secure as often as he could, an Allanar N3 with a unique blue star pattern across her hull. In fact, as they neared the exit, they came upon her, and Han patted the ship affectionately as he dipped under her low wings.

The receiving room was empty as they stepped in, not even anyone behind the counter, and Han called out into the space, announcing themselves. After a lag, a tall, sickly pale Twi'lek stepped out, scrutinizing Han from the doorway before approaching the counter.

"You took long enough. We had begun to think you hadn't made it," the Twi'lek hissed in Huttese, smirking with satisfaction at his taunt.

Han snorted a dry laugh. Fortuna wasn't exactly personable–Han particularly loathed the beady red eyes and the undeserved haughtiness–but the tail-head *did* touch the seat of power, or at least touched it by a degree or two removed.

"Yeah," Han offered, tossing the strongbox up onto the counter, "made it all the way to Socorro and back. Too bad you didn't come with, we coulda stopped over at Ryloth. Might have made for a wild homecoming for you."

At that, Fortuna stiffened up, suddenly all business, pulling up the data about Han's trip and beginning the process of logging the contents of the delivery before him. He asked Han a series of curt questions, showing impatience as the smuggler languidly responded, the latter acutely aware of just how sensitive the Twi'lek could be about his rather ignominious ejection from his homeworld and

reveling in the discomfort he was causing by dragging out their interaction.

The job properly documented, Fortuna then grabbed the strongbox and slipped away, disappearing again behind a doorway that led to the vault. Han grinned to himself–this was working. Sure, the actual contents would still need to be counted and verified, but something told him that Fortuna didn't just hang out in that back room and count coins all day. Allegedly, the Twi'lek had a weakness for ryll, and the solitude of the back room would offer the perfect cover. Han added the Twi'lek to his list of scapegoats.

"Ugh, where is he?" abruptly came a gravely voice behind the man and the Wookiee.

Han coolly pivoted on his heel, identifying the speaker by her unmistakable voice, the side effect of years spent in a room filled with hookah smoke. She had asked the question rhetorically, certainly not expecting either of the room's occupants to answer her. Ignoring Han and Chewie, she marched up to the counter, then craned her ear to listen. Having discerned her answer, she stiffly sucked in a breath to wait.

Deino had no last name and no use for one. Everyone knew the majordomo to Jiliac the Hutt, and having seen her once, she could easily be picked out from a crowd by her signature headdress, a tall, squarish design that always perfectly matched her floor-length silk dresses. She was human, probably middle-aged, still strikingly beautiful in an austere yet graceful way. She never said much, and that was a good quality to have in a majordomo.

Bib Fortuna, ignorant to her entry, came back around the corner and damn near dropped the credits he had bundled in his hands at the sight of Deino. Nervously, he hurried to the counter and spilled the coins, attempting in vain to suppress his anxiety at her presence. His quivering inquiry into her arrival was met with a brusque response.

"Jabba has requested you. Don't ask me why."

"Of course," Fortuna supplicated. "Let me just finish here."

Impatiently, he gestured for Han to come forward, hastening him with impatient clicks of his long fingernails on the countertop.

Han wouldn't hesitate to get paid, but as he stepped up, the shape and color of the money on the table registered to him, and he shook his head. "I don't take the peggat. You have to give it to me in credits."

"You'll take what you're offered," Fortuna argued back.

"I will *not*," Han rebutted, a slight edge to his voice. "I made that deal with the Hutts forever ago–I don't take payment in anything but credits."

The Twi'lek opened his mouth to rebut, but Deino interjected first. "Just give it to him," she demanded, her exasperation clear.

Fortuna clamped his mouth closed at her order, flashing a wrothful look at Han with those eerie red eyes before gathering up the coins on the counter and vanishing again.

"Thanks," Han offered, smiling warmly in anticipation of her turning to acknowledge him.

"*Not* a favor," the woman corrected sharply, barely turning her head as she answered.

Han took the clarification in silence, only exchanging surprised glances with Chewie, then resigning himself to waiting quietly. He shifted his weight around, struggling to stem off his building impatience, and actually felt a sense of relief when Fortuna returned.

"Fifteen hundred credits," the Twi'lek replied flatly as he placed the stacks down, then waited as Han inspected them. The smuggler picked up the top bullion, a one hundred piece credit, then identified and counted the rest of the denominations. They totaled correctly.

"Nice doing business with you," he crooned, giving Fortuna a singular nod. As he strolled away, he began organizing the slips into various pockets across his person. Smaller value credits always went in his pants pocket, in case someone tried to mug him. He put higher value credits in his front breast pocket, in case the mugger tried to

insist he had more on him. The highest value credit slips, though, went on the inside of his vest, nearest his skin. Let someone try and take those from him. Let them see what would happen.

He was doing the math in his head as they wove their way out of the Palace. A hundred would need to go directly to Shug, then they needed money for fuel, the rent on the apartment was due shortly, then provisions for the ship, then perhaps the part for the coaxium regulator, and then–

He stopped short, frustrated. The valves for the coaxium regulators were unfortunately not the only current item that needed replacing on the little Sorosuub *Starmite*. In the few months since he'd bought her, he'd also had to completely replace the sublight motivator, haggle repeatedly with a recalcitrant navicomputer that had left him stranded a handful of times without coordinates, and even had to wrestle with the damn gangplank. The 'Suub had been especially finicky the past few trips, including a handful of times when she wouldn't transition into hyperspace without considerable cajoling. Nor had her failures been the typical hiccup that added character to a ship. Instead, these were the kinds of errors that made Han sick to his stomach–the types of malfunctions that led to spontaneous explosions and shield generator fails and all sorts of defects that could leave them at a dead-stop in space...or worse. Fifteen hundred seemed nothing to sneeze at, but it always slipped right through his fingers.

They finally came to the large square outside the Hutt Palace, and Han's eyes shot straight to the distant horizon to check the weather. Sure enough, the sky churned, violent and dark, threatening to unleash its torrent at a moment's notice. It poured here every day, to the minute, soaking the already gray city in misery, making the cluttered streets awash in discarded refuse that would bundle at the neglected sewers. The rain was unforgiving, and the entirety of this side of the moon cleared out to wait until the storms waned. When the clouds passed, though, they would take the bulk of the humidity with them. Even the stench washed out temporarily, offering the denizens of Nar Shaddaa a few fleeting hours in the evening of uncorrupted air.

And yet, by dawn the next day, the heat and the humidity and the malodor would return.

As the rain appeared imminent, they needed to catch the tram that ran from the square into the Corellian Sector. Nar Shaddaa was constructed of a dizzying maze of levels and gangways and stairwells, all haphazardly and tenuously linked. The square sat quite low at Level 3, but the tram operated at Level 7, so he and Chewie crossed towards the station platform. As they neared, the area became more congested, and it heightened his uneasiness. Coming to the lift that would take them up to the boarding platform, Han surveyed either side of him at the encampments of the homeless, a mix of the destitute, the drunk, and the perpetually strung out. Most would keep to themselves, but occasionally one would get confrontational or even belligerent. Having Chewie with him helped deter many of the lazier thieves–Wookiees had proven rarer and rarer in the last decade, even on Nar Shaddaa, but their reputation rightly preceded them. The well-worn grip on his blaster helped dissuade even more, though he would never put it past someone particularly daring or stupid to try him. He'd hadn't had cause to discharge his weapon since coming here; he wouldn't hesitate if he needed to, either.

Coming off the lift, he checked the announcement board for the tram to see that a ride would arrive in just a few minutes. Cognizant of the weight of the coins in his vest, he lifted his chin and casually scanned the platform. No one seemed especially interested, however. Many of the other patrons just stood with eyes downcast, deadset on minding their own business. Unconvinced, the smuggler continued surveying. To Chewie's left were a pair of humans who were stiffly discussing some personal business; behind him was a family of Sullustans with an especially young kid who kept loudly asking questions and getting hushed by the parents; and to his right, a single male Twi'lek who nervously shifted his weight back and forth. In the distance, Han heard the hum of the tram. Sure enough, as he looked up the rail, a series of cars were gliding toward them, the headlamp on the front car broken.

People began to instinctively move forward in their eagerness to board, but Han and Chewie stayed stock still. They'd be the last to get on; that meant they could also hurry off, if need be. The movement of the crowd around Han, regular though it was, left him uneasy. This moment was its own opportunity: someone might wait until he was almost on the tram before they tried to bash, strike, or stab him and dash off with the pelf at his breast. His shoulders stiffened up as he continued to watch, conscious to not let himself be distracted by circumstance.

Sure enough, movement caught his attention, way back at his periphery–it didn't move forward, but sideways. Towards them. Chewie noticed it, too, and grumbled, then turned to check in the other direction; an ambush on the two of them would be smart. As Chewie made no noise beside him, Han understood this was a solitary attack. He surreptitiously studied the crowd, trying to pick out exactly what it was he had detected. It was easier said than done in the shuffle of everyone around him, but then he spotted what it was that had disquieted him: a teenage boy, a stinging cockiness in his gaze, had begun to close the distance. He had a deftness to his step, his head whipping over his shoulder to repeatedly check the oncoming tram, then snapping back around to keep eyes on the man and the Wookiee.

The tram arrived and lurched to a stop. As the doors opened, the other patrons stepped on, and the boy drew closer. Slowly, Han stepped forward as well, his gaze ostensibly forward but still watching. Chewie followed a beat behind him, an awkwardness to his step, as though Han's movement caught him off guard. The crowd shuffled forward, and Han moved with them again, approaching the doors. The boy crept ever nearer, more intently watching the closer he got. Still, Han paid him no mind, his attention seemingly wrapped up in monitoring the bustle closer to him.

Seeing his chance, the boy tensed to make his grab. Before he could lunge forward, though, he found an emitter nozzle at his windpipe. His whole body frozen in shock, the boy's eyes–wide in

surprise–didn't blink so long as Han held his blaster against his throat.

"Pick a different mark, Kid," Han breathed, then in one smooth motion, he reholstered his weapon and finished stepping on the tram, the doors closing as he found his footing. The other passengers had watched, and an uncomfortable silence gripped the train car, so that only the grinding of the tracks could be heard.

It was Chewie who broke the quiet. [*I have a distaste for your insistence on showmanship*.]

Han shrugged nonchalantly. "It's good to make an impression sometimes," he said out the side of his mouth. Impression made, the train rode on, mute.

The Spacebarn sat at the end of the line for the Corellian Sector route, bordering on the edge of the Industrial Sector. The rain had only just begun as they neared, starting with a few warning salvos of thunder before unleashing the full torrent of the storm. Luckily, the tram terminus connected to an indoor commercial mall that would take them the rest of the way. It was a smooth enough walk, with only the occasional encounter with a beggar posted outside the abandoned storefronts and the off-putting solicitations of the area's hard-working females to come inside the shrouded parlors for a release. Finally, beside a noodle bar that surprisingly impressed, they could access the lift that would take them down to Shug's.

As the lift descended, beneath it sprawled a hangar, large enough for twenty small to mid range vessels. Han grimaced again to have had his spot taken, though a part of him accepted that none of these belonged to anyone truly but Shug. It was first come, first serve, and the mechanic wasn't in the business of turning down customers. And yet, each of the pilots had their favorite spot, and Shug could be "forgetful" about listing a bay as available when its usual occupier was due back. Considering how ornery he'd seen some of the pop-in customers to be, the smuggler questioned then how much of this forgetfulness was kindness and how much of it was the mechanic choosing the devil he knew. Obviously, that hadn't stopped him this

time.

Shug's office lay at the other end of the facility, though the mechanic rarely sat back with his heels up. He more than likely had his hands buried in some engine, so the both of them swept their heads back and forth, peering into each bay as they passed. It was Chewie who eventually spotted him, dexterously perched on the outer hull of an unfamiliar craft in Bay 7, heavily masked with a welder in one hand and his pliers in the other. Somehow, despite the shower of sparks around him, the mechanic picked out the arm-waving from the docking bay doorway, and at sight of the smuggler and the Wookiee, paused his work and climbed down from the ship.

"You actually came," the mechanic started as he closed the distance, his three-fingered hand rustling the sweat-stained hair from his neck. Shug Ninx's human heritage unquestionably dominated his physique, but whatever else he had in the mix left him with splotches of green and blue markings across his otherwise tawny skin. Elsewhere in the Galaxy, particularly in the Core, such admixture would cause him issues, but no one around here cared. That was the beauty of the Outer Rim.

Han snorted at the dig, rummaging into his jacket and removing a single credit slip. The mechanic quickly palmed the ingot, weighed it in his hand, then tucked it into one of his myriad pockets. He swept a quick glance behind him, inspecting the bay for its occupant, before turning back to Han, the stress evident on his face.

"Some Gotal came in whooping and hollering about some busted catalyzer. Said someone up in New Vertica ripped him off. We got 'em straight, and they'll probably leave soon. Then you can have your spot back."

"Thanks," Han offered, genuine. He squinted to inspect the ship that had stolen his spot. Sleek and clean, it looked much too nice for a smuggler's hold like the Spacebarn. "Where they headed?"

"They said toward RN II to Ashara. Near my neck of the woods. You ever been up that way?"

Han was slow to answer. Ringneldia II, Shug's homework of

Falko, a whole slew of places he'd seen on the job board…they all sat in the Centrality Sector, and that corner of space sat a little too close for comfort to the now Imperial-dominated Mid Rim. He'd done everything he could to skirt around all such places so far. At some point, he surmised, he'd have to just pull the trigger–bigger risks meant bigger rewards–but with the way the damn 'Suub kept breaking down… "Not yet," he managed.

Shug stared off wistfully. "Too bad. Great damn restaurant in Ashara. Best glazed kell I ever had. Had next to nothing in my pocket–could barely rub two decicreds together–but I went back to that place the next couple nights." He smiled, the glitter of memory in his eyes. "I slept outside the port that last night–couldn't afford a room anymore. Managed to work my way onto a transport vessel that needed a hand." He scrutinized the appendage still streaked in engine grime, then flexed his three fingers. "Even if it wasn't a full hand."

Han inhaled long, his hands coming to his hips. "That kid anywhere around here?"

"Jarik?" Shug questioned. "Uh, yeah, I think I saw him not too long ago. Why, you got something for him?"

"Rodian hemolymph," Han answered. He turned to Chewie. "Go take a lap and see if you can find him."

The Wookiee stiffened, his cowl standing slightly on edge. [*I am not your lackey*.]

Han groaned. "Will you just *go*?!" he griped, gesturing deeper into the Spacebarn.

The Wookiee huffed but sulkily conceded, walking further down the corridor.

Han watched him leave for a beat, then remembered and yelled out after him. "Tell him he's gonna need a freezer cart to move that stuff! And tell him to start by making some calls up to the hospitals–I ain't interested in wingin' it out in the bazaar!" Turning back to Shug, he added under his breath, "Take a whole damn month to sell that stuff that way."

"You comin' in just to dock or you need somethin'?" the

mechanic asked.

"We can start with a refuel, and then…." At that, Han's voice drifted, not only recalling but prioritizing the list of items and tasks and repairs, then resumed the calculations in his head, subtracting from his total what this maintenance could likely cost him. The hemolymph, at least, would bring in profit, possibly as much as another four hundred–*if* the kid could do the transaction right. That would offset the rent on the apartment, at least, with a little left over.

Only when the Corellian looked up did he register Shug's silence and blank stare. Han shifted his weight to the side, frowning. "Hey," he entreated, "I've got the money."

The mechanic jutted out his lower lip. "I didn't say anything. But now that you mention it, I may be able to source you a whole coax regulator. Last I saw, the whole part might need replacement. It'd be cheaper for you in the long run if you sprang for it, rather than just replacing the valves. Safer, too."

Han held his breath for a moment, then let it out with an uneasy laugh: that was more than he'd factored. "Yeah, Shug, but–"

The mechanic read Han's apprehension and put his hands up. "Hey, I get it. But I'm just saying, it's not easy to find parts for her. I'm not sure when I'm gonna be able to get my hands on something like this again." He combed his fingers through his dark blonde hair, then scratched at his scalp, thinking. "Sorosuub needs to stick to the landspeeder market. They've got no business trying to play with the big heads."

"You'll get no argument from me on that," Han grumbled. "Any chance you still have those secondhand valves?"

The mechanic snorted. "I do. I don't recommend them–her type doesn't take well to off-brand–but I have them."

"Well, I'll need them," he conceded, then glanced around the hangar. "Is Mako around?"

"Maybe, but I doubt it. He's waiting on a shipment to come in–supplier said it wouldn't be here until the morning. You know him, he ain't gonna stick around. You Corellians have that in common.

Impatient–the whole lot of you."

Han ignored the rib, and instead rolled his eyes to think of how exactly the smuggler was occupying his time. Mako Spince had a penchant for making his money and then blowing it on whatever distracting outlet he could. Long as they'd been friends, he'd always been like that–a taste for the indulgent and the outrageous.

"What's he need a shipment for?" he asked, turning back to the mechanic. "Somethin' happen?"

Shug's face scrunched up. "Said he had a run in with some pirates. Fought his way out, obviously, but took some damage to his weapons systems."

Immediately, Han spun to gawk at the ship in the bay opposite. Inside, only dimly lit by the default lighting of the hangar sat a gunmetal gray ship. She rested heavy on her frame, a bulky, hulking vessel. *Punching Out* wasn't the fastest, but she could take a beating and give it back twice as hard. And, by the looks of it, that's exactly what she'd done her last trip. Streaks of laser fire marred her hull, and Han could see the pit of charred black where the cannons on the starboard side had once been. The ship had not been rammed, so that removed the Qerethi as suspects. And Mako had made it out alive, which meant it couldn't have been the Neshari Concord or the Yarrex.

"The Corsairs?" Han guessed over his shoulder.

"That's what Mako thinks. Said he might have seen the snake on one of their ships, but wasn't sure." The mechanic shook his head. "Feels like they're more brazen to me. Never heard of them out as far as Utapau. But, then again, Empire didn't use to be there, either."

Han grimaced at Shug's observation. Planet after planet had fallen into Imperial control in the last decade and a half, the Empire slowly eating up territory and planets and breaking economies to either suit their purposes or fold in the face of their dominant and ever-growing military regime. The Core near the center of the galaxy, already a cohesive unit under the previous Republic, had succumbed quickly. A central hub established, the Empire had then begun

branching out, slowly gobbling up additional star systems and picking off useful colonies on the periphery to support the burgeoning needs of the war machine. Utapau was newly acquired Empire territory. Pirates had never hung around it much, but the imposition of the Imperials meant a chokehold on imports and exports. Exploiting such restrictions was the specialty of smugglers, but unfortunately, where smugglers went, pirates went, too.

"Rho told me he never listened about how to sidestep them," Han remarked dryly, still staring at *Punching Out*. "Always went barreling down the middle."

Shug snickered. "Well, he's reckless. You all have that in common, too."

Distantly, Han nodded, then his gaze surreptitiously eyeballed the bay nearest the back. Upon inspection, he acknowledged with a sigh that the darkness of the doorway and the red light above the entrance meant the bay sat empty: its usual occupier had already left for her run.

"You missed her by all of half an hour," came Shug's voice behind him.

Han turned tightly, barely able to suppress his surprise to have been caught and hurriedly forced a smirk. "Tell me she didn't kiss you goodbye in my absence," he jibed.

"No accounting for taste," the mechanic teased, his eyes twinkling, before gesturing behind him at the Gotal's ship. "Listen, I gotta turn-to. Gimme thirty minutes. An hour. We'll get you in."

They parted after a quick handshake. Han held the grin, but soon as Shug had made it about ten paces away, his face fell. Once again, he glanced down at the empty bay towards the front, then shrugged, figuring he'd just have to see her when she came back, though the mildest little pang hitched at his breastbone that she'd not waited to say goodbye. That was just like Salla, though–seldom sentimental–and he supposed that was the exact thing that made them work.

With no bay of his own here to return to, no urgent task to

complete, no friend to kill time with, an emptiness tugged somewhere in his chest, reaching up for his throat. His brow hardened and with a tight swallow, he forced the feeling down.

He needed to focus. Chewie–where the hell was Chewie? He stretched his neck to search across the hangar, his eyes straining in the dark to catch sight of the unmistakable mass of the Wook. His hunt proved fruitless. Exasperated, he let go of a long, grumbling sigh. The big lug hovered when he wasn't needed, and then disappeared when he was.

Wait…he'd need to wait. He shifted his weight around, his hands briefly finding his hips, his attention searching for something–anything–to take his mind off whatever might surface. He scanned what he could see of the hangar: bodies and parts and machinery moved around almost in a dance, but nothing particular caught his eye. Then, in the distance, a spray of yellow sparks erupted into the air, grinding at some ship obscured by its respective bay. Ever so faintly, he heard the whine of the gears and the sharp, resistant squeal of the hull, and he watched for a beat, entranced by the fireworks show.

At the noise of someone else, a stranger, coming to pass him in the corridor, he remembered himself. Giving the customary nod, he moved to the side to let her pass. She slipped by with little acknowledgement, a stiff dismissal that needled him more than he wanted it to. His eyes followed her down the corridor, watched her slip into her hangar, saw the green light above the bay entrance start to blink in warning of impending take-off.

He swallowed again. No need to be upset, he reassured. That was just how this place worked. Come. Go. Get what you need. Mind your own business. Sidestep who you need to.

Do what it takes to thrive on the Smuggler's Moon.